

LIFE ON the frontier

THE AMERICAN WILD WEST

The settlement of the American West is a much-romanticized period, but undeniably one during which female pioneers were granted unprecedented opportunities for independence. However, westward expansion took place at the expense of America's indigenous peoples; the opportunities created for white women were often founded on the destruction of Native women's traditional homelands and their way of life.

In the years after the founding of the US, its citizens explored land farther and farther west. As early as 1787, Congress adopted the Northwest Ordinance, which allowed US citizens to settle and govern Native American lands. Tribal nations protested the invasions of territories that their people had occupied for millennia, but the government saw westward expansion as the country's destiny and pushed Native people to join US society. In 1862, Congress passed the Homestead Act, which offered settlers 160 acres of land, free of charge, which they could claim if they agreed to live on and farm ("improve") the land for

five years. The Act provided a unique opportunity for single and widowed women to provide for themselves, as women could claim the title under their own names. However, married women could not file a claim. Between 1863–1930, homesteaders claimed at least 3 million acres a year.



◀ Native doll

Dolls were often made by grandmothers for their grandchildren. This one shows a Sioux woman in riding attire, typical of the nomadic Plains people, and a dress style worn by adult women.

